

10

Standing in the middle of the road is very dangerous – you get knocked down by the traffic from both sides.

Margaret Thatcher

Do you find decision-making easy or difficult?

Learning objectives: Unit 10

Business communication skills

Discussing making decisions in difficult situations; Doing a quiz on life-and-death decisions; Giving advice on worst-case scenarios or workplace dilemmas; Inserting missing articles into two texts; Fluency: Holding a crisis management meeting

Reading Website extract: Worst-case scenarios; Company crises

Listening Advice on surviving worst-case scenarios; Decision-making meetings; Case study: Coca-Cola crisis

Vocabulary Marketing

Grammar Articles

Phrase bank Decision-making

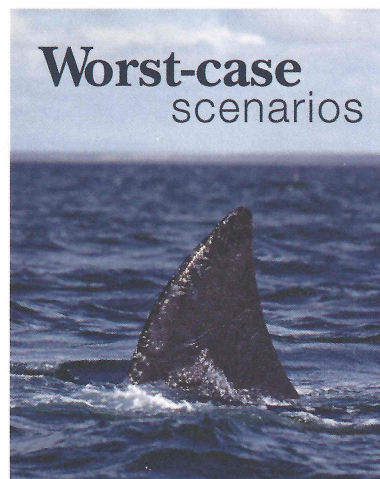
In company interviews

Units 8–10

Making decisions

1 When was the last time you were faced with a difficult decision and were unable to make up your mind? How did you decide in the end, or was the decision made for you?

2 You may be a cool-headed decision maker in the office, but would you know what to do in a real life-or-death situation? Read the following extract from an unusual website and discuss the questions.



The principle behind this site is a simple one: you just never know.

You never really know what nasty surprises life has in store for you – what is lurking around the corner, what is hovering over your head, what is swimming beneath the surface. You never know when you might be called on to perform an act of extreme bravery and to choose life or death by your own actions.

But when you are called, we want to be sure that you know how to react. We want you to know what to do when the pilot passes out and you have to land the plane. We want you to know what to do when you see that shark fin heading toward you ...

- a** What kind of things 'lurking around the corner', 'hovering over your head' or 'swimming beneath the surface' do you think the website is referring to? **U can't know**
 - b** Have you ever found yourself in a really dangerous situation where you needed to act quickly? Tell the story. **No**
 - c** What worst-case scenario would you least like to face:
1 at work? **2** in life?
- 3** Work in two groups. Hold an emergency meeting to decide what decisions you'd make in real life-and-death situations. There are four items on your 'agenda' and you have just five minutes to decide what action to take. Group A your worst-case scenarios are below and on page 64. Group B turn to page 124.

1 On a driving holiday in India you lose control of your hire-car travelling downhill at 70 mph on a mountain road. You've no brakes and there's a 300m drop to the valley below. Do you:

- a** try to jump out of the car and roll to safety?
- b** steer away from the cliff edge and into the mountainside to stop the car?
- c** steer into the crash barriers on the cliff edge to slow the car down?

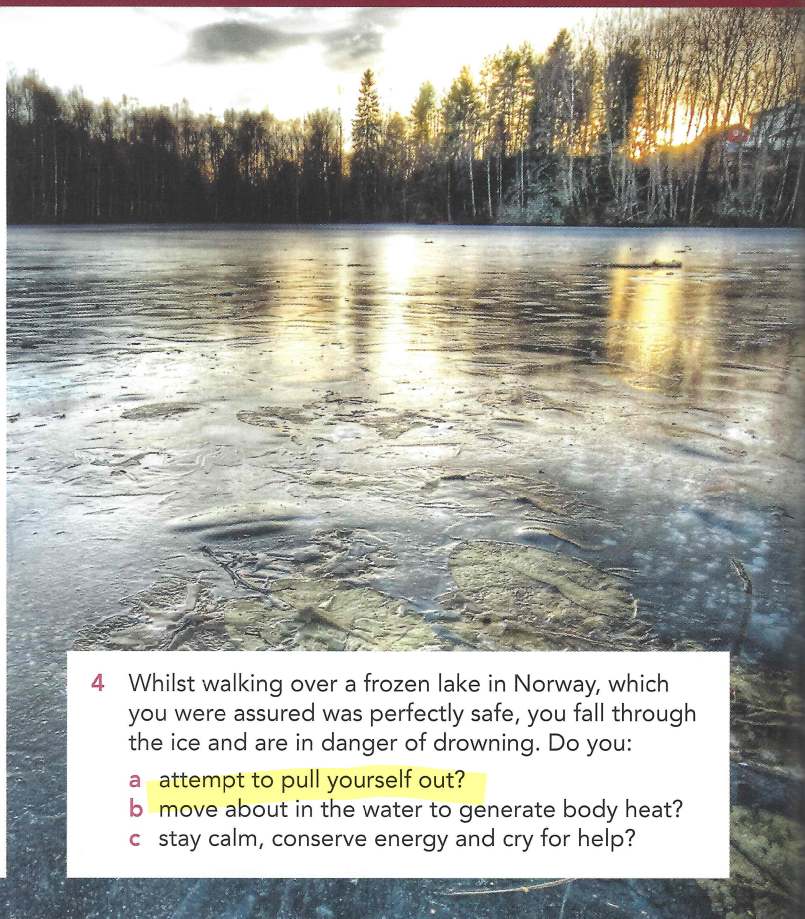


2 On a trek in the Chilean Andes you get cut off from the rest of your group and become hopelessly lost. As you try to work out which direction to take, you are confronted by a hungry mountain lion. Do you:

- a** lie down and play dead?
- b** shout and flap your coat at the animal?
- c** run and hide (maybe find a tree to climb)?



- 3 During a flight over the Grand Canyon in a private plane, your pilot passes out and you have to land the plane yourself. You manage to reach the airfield. Do you:
- a keep the nose of the plane pointing above the horizon as you descend to the runway?
 - b slow down to about 60 mph as you touch down and then hit the brakes hard?
 - c keep the plane at a steady altitude of 150 feet as you approach the beginning of the runway?



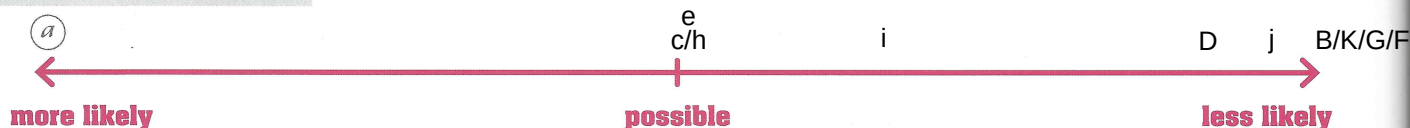
- 4 Whilst walking over a frozen lake in Norway, which you were assured was perfectly safe, you fall through the ice and are in danger of drowning. Do you:
- a attempt to pull yourself out?
 - b move about in the water to generate body heat?
 - c stay calm, conserve energy and cry for help?

4 Work with a partner from the other group. Briefly summarize the scenarios you faced and the decisions you took.

5  2.22-2.29 Now listen to some advice on how to survive the eight worst-case scenarios in 3. How many lives did you lose? Which group did better?

6 Put the following expressions on the scale below according to how likely they are. Most of them were in the advice you just listened to. The first one has been done for you.

- | | |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------|
| a You've a good chance. | g You've blown your chances. |
| b You don't stand a chance. | h There's a fair chance. |
| c There's a 50-50 chance. | i There's an outside chance. |
| d Your chances are slim. | j It's a million-to-one chance. |
| e You're in with a chance. | k No chance! |
| f The chances are remote. | |



7 Complete expressions a-n using the nouns and verbs in the boxes. They were all in the advice in 5.

bet circumstances idea mistake move point thing

- a Your best bet is to shout and flap your coat at the animal.
- b Do not in any circumstances try to stand up on the ice.
- c It's a good idea to brake as soon as you've gained control of the steering.
- d There's not much point trying to force the door open.
- e By far the most sensible thing to do is to open the car window.
- f Just grabbing on to the nearest person with a parachute is not a smart move.
- g It's a common mistake to think the shark's nose is the best area to target.

do forget make put resist take think

- h** Don't even think about jumping from a moving vehicle.
i Resist the temptation to run from a mountain lion.
j put any ideas of playing dead out of your mind.
k make sure that the nose of the plane is six inches below the horizon.
l Take care to land on your back to avoid breaking it.
m Forget about trapping air inside a sinking car.
n You'd Do much better to strike at the eyes or gills.

8 Work with a partner. Practise using some of the expressions in 6 and 7 by advising them on how to handle one of the following situations. Don't worry if you can't give expert advice!

Worst-case scenarios

- on a round-the-world cruise the ocean liner you're on hits an iceberg and starts to sink
- during a trip across the Australian Outback, your car breaks down in the middle of nowhere
- a poisonous snake has crawled into your sleeping bag

Workplace dilemmas

- your boss is working you to death
- a colleague is taking the credit for all your ideas
- you've been passed over for promotion – again!
- there's a rumour your company is about to announce redundancies

'Gentlemen, I take it we are all in complete agreement on the decision here.' Alfred P. Sloan, the head of General Motors, looked around the committee room table. His senior managers nodded in assent. 'Then,' continued Sloan, 'I propose we postpone further discussion of the matter until our next meeting to give ourselves time to develop disagreement and perhaps gain some understanding of what the decision is about.'

John Adair
Effective Decision-Making

The decision-making process

1 Read the anecdote about Alfred P. Sloan, the man who built General Motors into the biggest company in the world. What point is being made about group decisions?

2  **2.30–2.32** Listen to extracts from three different decision-making meetings and answer the questions.

1 An industrial dispute

- a** Why is Dan so concerned about a strike?
b Who's the calmest person at the meeting?

2 Political instabilities

- a** What's Hans's objection to the proposal?
b What's Andrea worried about?

3 A product recall

- a** Whose side is Laura on?
b Do you think Simon has already made up his mind?

3 You heard the following idiomatic expressions in 2. Can you remember the missing words? The first two letters are given. The meaning of the idioms in brackets may help you.

- a** the ball is in their co_____ (we're waiting for someone else to make a decision)
b jump to co_____ (decide too quickly without considering all the facts)
c when it comes to the cr_____ (when a decision finally has to be made)
d sit on the fe_____ (refuse to support either side in an argument)

4 The following remarks were also all in the meetings in 2. Replace the words and phrases in **bold** with similar ones from the box.

advantages and disadvantages alternative come to complete support
I don't think we should make a decision information intuition the main thing
opinions plan pool our ideas serious thought stand by suggest undecided
we need to take our time on this we're running out of time we unanimously agree

- a** Look, **time is short** _____. So let's **put our heads together** _____ and see what we can **come up with** _____.
- b** Okay, we've weighed up the various **pros and cons** _____. Now it's time to **reach** _____ a decision and **stick to** _____ it.
- c** **I don't want us rushing into things** _____. This whole issue requires **careful consideration** _____.
- d** I take it **we're all in agreement** _____ that **our first priority** _____ is to safeguard the well-being of our personnel.
- e** Well, then, I don't see we have any **option** _____ but to give this proposal our **full backing** _____.
- f** I'd like your **input** _____ on this before committing us to any definite **course** _____ of action.
- g** I'm **in two minds** _____ about it. At this stage **I think we should keep our options open** _____.
- h** Well, in the absence of more reliable **data** _____, I think I'm going to have to go with my **gut instinct** _____ on this one.

Crisis management

1 What sort of crises can companies be faced with these days? Can you think of recent examples of any of the following?

accusations of fraud a consumer boycott an environmental disaster a hostile takeover bid
insider trading a lawsuit mass redundancies a product recall

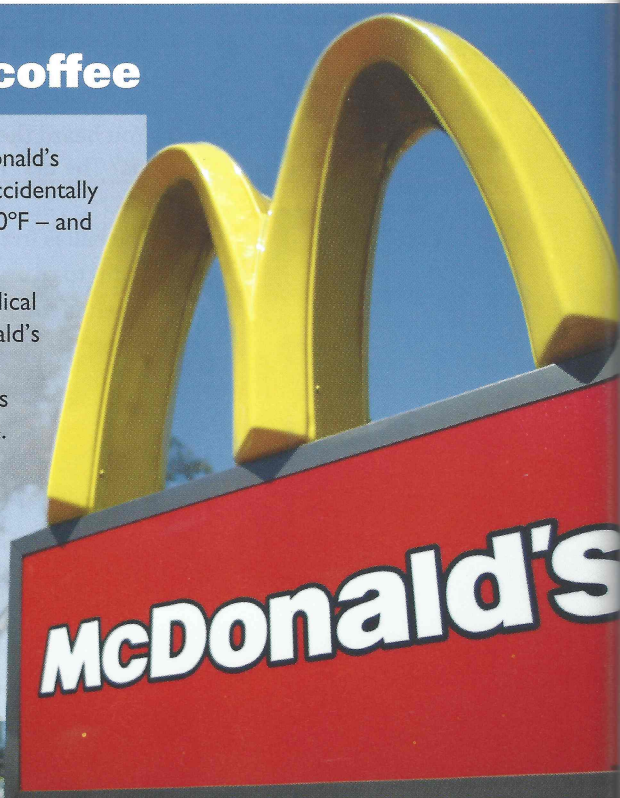
2 Work in two groups. Group A read about a crisis at McDonald's, Group B at Mercedes. Twenty-five articles (*a*, *an* and *the*) are missing from each text. Write them in. If you do the exercise correctly, both groups should use *a*, *an* and *the* the same number of times.

A McDonald's crying over spilled coffee

In 1994 Stella Liebeck, New Mexico grandmother, ordered coffee at McDonald's drive-through restaurant. Minutes later, sitting in her car in car park, she accidentally spilled coffee – heated, in response to customer preference, to scalding 180°F – and suffered severe burns requiring surgery. Crisis was about to unfold.

When McDonald's refused to take responsibility for paying woman's medical bills, she went to attorney and sued company. At trial jury found McDonald's liable and awarded \$200,000 in compensatory damages (less \$40,000 for negligence on Liebeck's part) and massive \$2.7 million in punitive damages because of what they saw as McDonald's unacceptably dismissive attitude.

One might have expected bad publicity to ruin McDonald's, but instead newspapers leapt to company's defence, declaring what nonsense court's verdict was. 'America has victim complex,' announced *San Francisco Chronicle*. Punitive damages were later reduced by judge to \$480,000 and, while awaiting appeal, parties made out-of-court settlement for undisclosed sum. But by then 'three million dollar coffee-spill' had already passed into corporate legend.

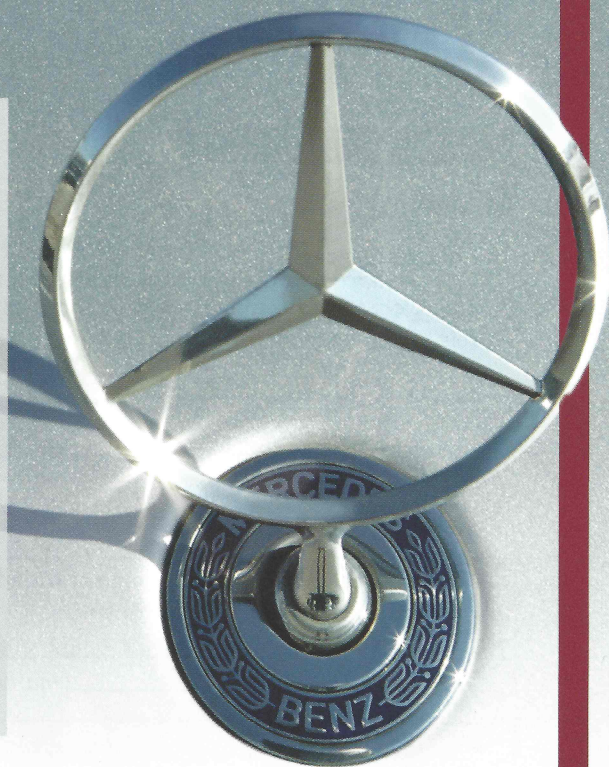


B Mercedes on a roll

In automotive industry trend for many years has been towards smaller, more economical vehicle. So in autumn of 1997, Daimler-Benz introduced new economy model, Mercedes 'A Class'. It was car designed to compete with ever-popular Volkswagen Golf. But just before November launch, disaster struck.

Swedish auto magazine had conducted what they called 'elk test' on new car. Test is standard in Sweden to make sure cars can steer to avoid large deer crossing road. But at just 60 kph 'A Class' overturned, injuring both test drivers. Storm immediately blew up in press and on TV, as buyers waiting to take delivery cancelled their orders. For Mercedes it was not only financial but image crisis too.

Daimler responded quickly, adding wider tyres, electronic stability mechanism and stronger anti-rollbars – all at no extra cost to customer. Highly successful advertising campaign and public support from Niki Lauda, ex-formula one racing champion, helped to restore consumer confidence in 'A Class' but at cost of hundreds of millions of dollars.



3 Summarize the story you read in 2 to a member of the other group. What lessons can be learned from how the companies behaved?

4 Which are the best things a manager can do in a crisis? Which do you think are good advice? Match the following collocations.

a deny	someone	g admit	honest
b stay	time	h take	data
c delegate	calm	i make	charge
d buy	decisive	j act	quickly
e blame	everything	k collect	nothing
f be	responsibility	l be	promises

5 Work in groups to act as crisis management consultants to the Coca-Cola Company. It is May 1999 and the world's most famous brand is in trouble ...

Step 1

 **2.33** Listen to the first part of the case and answer the questions.

- a** How many Cokes are sold each day?
- b** How would you describe Coca-Cola's advertising strategy?
- c** What has just happened?
- d** Which markets are directly involved in the crisis?
- e** Calculate how much those markets are worth in annual sales.

Step 2

 **2.34** Listen to the second part of the case and answer the questions.

- a** What do the following figures refer to?
+25% -13%
- b** What is the significance of these figures?
- c** What have the inspectors at the Belgian bottling plant found?
- d** What is the toxicologist's verdict?
- e** Who is benefiting from Coca-Cola's current problems?

Step 3

Hold a meeting to decide what recommendations to make to your client. As well as the information you have just heard, read the article and agenda on page 121.



In company interviews
Units 8–10

10 Making decisions

Vocabulary

Marketing

The marketplace

1 Complete the adjectives by writing in the missing vowels. The adjectives range from positive to negative.

The market is b _ _ m _ _ ng thr _ _ v _ _ ng
h _ _ lthy b _ _ y _ _ nt
v _ _ l _ _ t _ _ l _ _ _ npr _ _ d _ _ ct _ _ bl _ _
w _ _ k sl _ _ gg _ _ sh
fl _ _ t d _ _ pr _ _ ss _ _ d

+
↓
-

2 Complete the sentence using some of the adjectives in 1 and information that is true for you.

The market for _____ in _____ is _____, whereas the _____ market is _____.

3 Complete the collocations by writing a noun from the box before each set of three nouns below.

advertising brand distribution market marketing

- a _____ mix / drive / strategy
- b _____ forces / research / share
- c _____ network / channels / costs
- d _____ campaign / expenditure / agencies
- e _____ awareness / loyalty / stretching

4 Which collocations in 3 are the following examples of?

- a Omnicom, Publicis, Doyle Dane Bernbach, Dentsu
- b competition, the state of the economy, political stability
- c 'the four Ps': product, place, price, promotion
- d wholesalers, retailers, sales reps
- e Virgin Cola, Camel watches, Ferrari sunglasses

5 Listed below are some of the terms commonly used in marketing departments, but the second word in each collocation has been switched with another in the same column. Can you switch them back? The first two have been done for you.

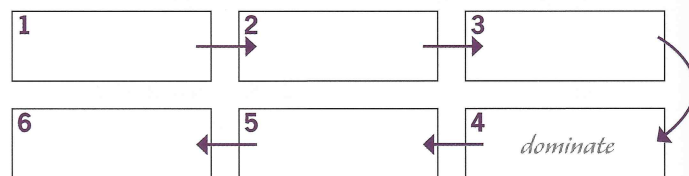
- a market **outlet** ← g subliminal **relations**
- b competitive **brand** ← h price **marketing**
- c retail **challenger** ← i niche **analysis**
- d mass **sensitivity** ← j public **advertising**
- e price **market** ← k consumer **market**
- f leading **advantage** ← l permission **war**

6 Which of the terms in 5 refer to:

- a the number two player in a market after the market leader?
- b the importance the customer gives to prices?
- c a small number of customers requiring a particular type of product or service?
- d the shop or store through which products are sold to the consumer?
- e a method of persuading consumers to buy by invisible, psychological means?
- f getting customers' permission before sending information to them?

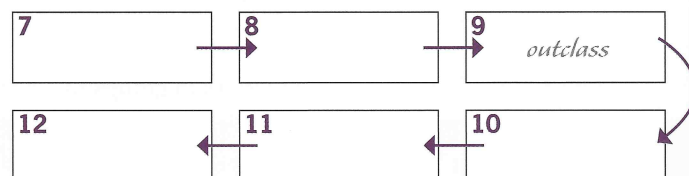
7 The verbs and verb phrases in the box all form strong collocations with 'the market'. Put them into the most likely chronological order. One of them has been done for you.

be squeezed out of break back into compete in
dominate enter target



The verbs and verb phrases in the box all form strong collocations with 'the competition'. Put them into the most likely chronological order. One of them has been done for you.

come up against destroy fight back against
outclass succumb to take on



Grammar

Articles

Complete the text with *a*, *an*, *the* or zero article Ø, as necessary.

They say 'All's fair in (1) Ø love and (2) Ø war'. And when it comes to getting (3) a good deal, (4) the same is true of (5) Ø business. For (6) Ø example, in 1803, (7) Ø/a half of what is now (8) the USA was actually bought from (9) the French for three cents (10) an acre! How were they able to get such (11) a bargain? At (12) the time, (13) the/Ø Emperor Napoleon was preparing to go to (14) Ø war with (15) Ø Britain and was desperate to sell.

The **indefinite article** is used:

- before a singular countable noun when it is unspecified and mentioned for the first time. *I need **a** holiday.*
- before singular countable nouns in exclamations. *What **a** day!; It was such **a** nuisance!*
- before the names of professions. *She's **an** engineer.*
- before a singular countable noun where a plural could be used to mean the same thing. *There's no such thing as **a** free lunch = There's no such thing as free lunches.*
- to mean per when talking about prices, speed, rates, etc. *€3 **a** kilo; three times **a** day.*

The **definite article** is used:

- before a noun that has been mentioned before. *I used to have two BMWs and a Lotus, but I had to sell **the** Lotus.*
- before a noun that is later specified in the same sentence. ***The** guy I met in Rio runs his own business.*
- when it is clear from the context what we are referring to. *I'll drop you off at **the** hotel.*
- when the thing referred to is unique. ***The** human race.*
- before an adjective referring to a group. ***The** Dutch.*

The **zero article** is used:

- before mass or abstract nouns. *Greed is good.*
- before the names of most countries. Exceptions include: the USA, the UK and the Netherlands.
- in certain fixed expressions. *Go to war.*

Phrase bank: Decision-making

Listed below are six key things you need to do in a decision-making meeting. Match each to three things you might say. The first one has been done for you as an example.

- 1 Encourage collaboration
- 2 Comment on options
- 3 Consider pros and cons
- 4 Advise caution
- 5 Check agreement
- 6 Commit to a decision

b			

a That's a big plus, as far as I'm concerned. But let's look at some of the minuses.

b Okay; I'd like everybody's input on this.

c We need to take our time on this.

d I don't see we have any option but to go ahead.

e So is that unanimous then?

f I think I'm going to have to go with my gut instinct on this one.

g To be honest, I'm in two minds about this.

h Okay, that's the upside. But what about the downside?

i This requires careful consideration.

j I take it we're all in agreement on this?

k Let's put our heads together and see what we can come up with.

l I'm not wholly in favour of this, but what alternative do we have?

m Okay, we've weighed up the advantages and disadvantages.

n Does anybody have any objections to that?

o So that's decided then.

p Let's pool our ideas on this.

q I don't want us rushing into things.

r Okay, so we're going to go with Marc's idea.

10 Making decisions

Worst-case scenarios (p63, ex3)

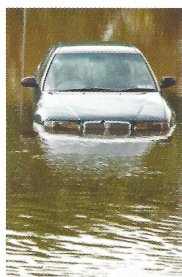
- 5 While staying in a hotel in Paris, you wake up to find the whole place is on fire. Your way down is blocked and you end up on the roof. Do you:

- a take a long run-up and jump onto the next building (a distance of four and a half metres)?
- b jump six floors down and land on your back in a truck packed with soft insulation materials?
- c leap well away from the building to clear obstructions and land in the truck?



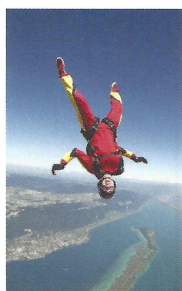
- 6 On a business trip to Amsterdam your taxi skids on a patch of oil and plunges off the road and into a canal. In seconds you are half-underwater. Do you:

- a force open the door and swim to safety (taking the driver with you)?
- b wind down the window fully to let the water in?
- c wind the window up to trap air inside the car in case you sink?



- 7 You agree to do a parachute jump for charity with a group of friends. But as you free-fall from 14000 feet at 120 mph both your parachute and emergency chute fail to open. Do you:

- a keep struggling with your emergency chute? It must work!
- b grab hold of the nearest member of the group before they open their chute?
- c take valuable time to attach yourself to the chest straps of another parachutist?



- 8 Whilst snorkelling off the Great Barrier Reef in north-eastern Australia, you suddenly see a large shark swimming swiftly towards you from the depths. Do you:

- a try to attack the shark's eyes?
- b punch the shark on the nose?
- c splash about and make a noise to frighten it away?



07 Coaching

(p45, ex10)

Work in groups of three and take turns to be the coach, the coachee and the observer.

Coach: Using the GROW model, listen, ask lots of questions and try to help your coachee identify their goals and develop a realistic plan of action within a timeframe they are comfortable with. Resist the temptation to give them advice unless you can see they are 'stuck'. If you do offer advice, make it clear that is what you are doing, but try not to influence the coachee too much. Show empathy and understanding, but remain neutral.

Coachee: Decide on a topic for the coaching conversation you're about to have. Topics you could discuss include communication skills, learning English for business, new work responsibilities, time management, stress and workload, career development, strategies for building your professional network, personality clashes at work, leadership and motivation issues. Try to focus on one specific aspect of the issue.

Observer: Watch the coaching session, but do not say anything. Take notes on how well the coach helps the coachee to deal with their own issues. Do they use the GROW model? Are they empathetic? Do they stick to a neutral coaching approach or move into a mentor role too much? How does the coachee respond? What is the outcome of the session? At the end of the meeting give both of your partners some brief feedback.

Scenario D

(p99, ex13)

Meetings checklist	Yes	No
Was the meeting well chaired?		
Was the objective clear?		
Were all participants able to express their ideas and opinions?		
Did participants listen carefully to each other?		
Did participants use appropriate disagreement strategies?		
Was the objective achieved?		
Change management checklist	Yes	No
Did participants explain the need for change?		
Did participants explain the benefits of the change?		
Did participants (plan to) recruit change champions?		
Did participants plan to provide tools and resources to facilitate the change?		
Did participants plan to continue to communicate about the change?		